TITLE:

Surendran Reddy's *Mayibuye Suite* (2001): Reimagining of the Organ in a Contemporary South African Composition

KEYWORDS:

Clazz

Mayibuye Suite

Stylistic Synthesis

Surendran Reddy

ABSTRACT

The music of the South African composer Surendran Reddy (1962–2010) represents a distinctive synthesis of Western classical traditions, jazz idioms, and African musical influences. His *Mayibuye Suite* (2001) for organ exemplifies this stylistic hybridity and offers an important contribution to contemporary organ repertoire. Drawing on approaches to South African organ composition, together with analytical frameworks derived from jazz theory and contemporary music analysis, this article examines the suite's three movements - *Prelude*, *An African Hymn*, and *Toccata* - with particular emphasis on harmonic language, rhythmic processes, and stylistic synthesis. This article situates the work within the broader cultural and socio-political context of post-apartheid South Africa and Reddy's own artistic philosophy, encapsulated in his concept of 'clazz', a fusion of classical and jazz idioms. The findings demonstrate how the *Mayibuye Suite* reimagines the expressive possibilities of the organ, transforming the instrument into a medium for intercultural musical dialogue while reflecting themes of displacement, cultural identity, and artistic hybridity.

1. INTRODUCTION

The twentieth and twenty-first centuries have witnessed an increasing convergence of musical traditions previously considered distinct. The boundaries between Western art music, jazz, and various vernacular traditions have become increasingly permeable, resulting in a range of hybrid musical practices. Within this broader cultural environment, composers have frequently sought to integrate diverse stylistic influences in ways that challenge conventional genre distinctions.

The organ, historically associated primarily with liturgical and classical traditions, has not remained immune to these developments. Contemporary composers increasingly explore the instrument's

potential beyond its conventional ecclesiastical role, incorporating elements drawn from jazz, popular music, and non-Western musical traditions. These developments reflect broader shifts in musical aesthetics and cultural identity.

Within the South African context, the works of Surendran Reddy occupy a particularly important position in this regard. Reddy's compositions demonstrate a distinctive synthesis of Western classical idioms, jazz harmonic language, African rhythmic sensibilities, and other contemporary influences. His music exemplifies the emergence of stylistic hybridity within South African art music during the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries.

Among Reddy's organ compositions, the *Mayibuye Suite* (2001) represents a particularly significant contribution to the repertoire. The work integrates classical compositional structures with jazz-derived harmonic and rhythmic techniques, while also drawing on African musical concepts and other contemporary musical genres. Through this synthesis, Reddy reimagines the expressive possibilities of the organ and articulates a broader vision of musical intercultural dialogue.

The Mayibuye Suite should also be considered within the broader development of South African organ composition. A number of South African composers have explored different forms of engagement between Western organ composition and African musical materials or culturally situated musical practices, including Stefans Grové's *Afrika Hymnus I, II* and *III*, Henk Temmingh's *Nkosi I, II* and *III*, Michael Blake's *San Polyphony,* and Kevin Volans's *Walking Song*. Within this broader repertoire, Reddy's *Mayibuye Suite* is distinctive in the extent to which jazz-derived harmonic and rhythmic procedures form an integral part of its compositional language.

While existing scholarship on South African organ music has addressed questions of African musical identity, intercultural composition, and the adaptation of indigenous musical materials, less attention has been given to the interaction between South African organ composition and jazz-derived harmonic language.

This article examines the *Mayibuye Suite* as both a musical and cultural artefact. By utilising analytical tools rooted in jazz theory and contemporary music analysis to map the suite's harmonic language and structural design, the article demonstrates how Reddy's compositional approach reflects his broader artistic philosophy and engagement with issues of cultural identity, displacement, and stylistic hybridity.

2. SURENDRAN REDDY AND THE EMERGENCE OF THE 'CLAZZ' IDIOM

Surendran Reddy was born in Durban, South Africa, in 1962 and quickly gained recognition as a remarkable musical talent. During his early career he pursued advanced musical studies and obtained several licentiate qualifications, including formal training at the Royal College of Music in London (Surendran Reddy, [s.a.]). His musical development was shaped by a wide range of influences, including Western classical repertoire, jazz improvisation, and South African musical traditions.

Reddy's early recordings as a pianist reveal a strong affinity for improvisation and stylistic experimentation. Two commercial recordings released in the mid-1990s consist largely of improvised piano works that incorporate thematic material from composers such as J.S. Bach and Mozart, alongside popular music and jazz influences (Van der Merwe, 2016:43-46). These recordings illustrate Reddy's tendency to blur stylistic boundaries and to treat musical genres as fluid rather than fixed categories.

Central to Reddy's artistic identity was the development of a personal compositional idiom that he referred to as 'clazz'. This term denotes a synthesis of classical and jazz idioms, often incorporating elements drawn from African musical traditions as well. Within this stylistic framework, Reddy sought to create music that transcended traditional genre boundaries and reflected a broader vision of cultural dialogue.

Reddy's philosophical approach to music was closely connected to this concept of stylistic hybridity. He emphasised the importance of exploring 'in-between cultures' (Reddy in Van der Merwe, 2016:30) as a means of bringing people together and fostering greater understanding through artistic expression. This perspective reflects broader trends in postmodern musical aesthetics, where the coexistence of multiple stylistic languages is often viewed as a positive and creative force.

In 1995, Reddy relocated to Konstanz in Germany, where he continued to develop his compositional style until his death in 2010. During this period, he composed his two major organ works: *Toccata for Madiba* (1997) and *Mayibuye Suite* (2001). Both works exemplify the mature phase of his compositional development and demonstrate the integration of jazz idioms within the context of Western organ composition.

3. SOUTH AFRICAN MUSICAL IDIOMS AND THEIR INFLUENCE ON *MAYIBUYE SUITE*

The development of South African jazz forms reflects a complex interaction between indigenous African musical traditions, imported American jazz styles, and the socio-political conditions of the

twentieth century (Thorpe, 2018:6). From the early decades of the twentieth century, South African musicians began to incorporate elements of American jazz into local music practices. However, these influences were not merely imitative; rather, they were integrated with indigenous rhythmic patterns, vocal traditions, and communal performance practices to create distinctly South African idioms. This forms an important part of the broader musical environment within which Reddy's compositional language can be understood.

Among the most influential of these idioms are marabi, mbaqanga, kwela, and ghoema. Each of these musical traditions developed within specific historical and cultural contexts and is characterised by distinctive rhythmic, harmonic, and melodic features. Collectively, they form an important part of the stylistic environment from which many South African jazz musicians and composers have drawn inspiration (ibid.).

Although Reddy spent a significant portion of his career in Europe, his musical language reflects an awareness of these traditions. While the *Mayibuye Suite* does not quote any specific South African jazz melodies, the work nevertheless incorporates rhythmic patterns, harmonic approaches, and stylistic gestures that resonate strongly with these musical idioms. Understanding these stylistic influences is therefore essential for interpreting the suite's broader musical and cultural significance.

Marabi

Marabi emerged between the 1890s and 1920s in South African townships like Sophiatown. It was the music of the urban working class, played in illicit bars called shebeens as a cultural refuge and a form of resilience against the oppression of apartheid (Olowodunoye, [s.a.]). The genre is built on cyclical, repetitive chord vamps, most commonly following a I–IV–I–V (or I–IV–V–I) progression in major keys. These simple, trance-like loops allowed songs to sustain communal dancing for extended periods (ibid.).

Marabi utilises short, singable melodies. It heavily features call-and-response patterns between lead voices or horns and the ensemble, frequently embellished with 'bluesy' flattened thirds and sevenths (ibid.). It is characterised by a lively 4/4 tempo with a distinct light swing or lilt. The style blends traditional African rhythmic sensibilities with the syncopation of American ragtime and stride piano, creating an energetic, 'irresistibly danceable' groove (ibid.).

In the context of Reddy's *Mayibuye Suite*, similar harmonic cycles appear in passages where alternating chord pairs generate a sense of continuous harmonic oscillation. Such patterns recall the repetitive harmonic structures associated with marabi performance.

Marabi piano playing is characterised by broken chord patterns, rhythmic ostinato, and syncopated accompaniment figures (ibid.). These textures bear a strong resemblance to the arpeggiated textures that dominate the *Prelude* of the *Mayibuye Suite*. Although Reddy adapts these patterns for the organ rather than the piano, the underlying principle remains similar: harmonic progression is articulated through continuous figuration rather than through discrete melodic gestures. This approach reflects a broader stylistic affinity between Reddy's compositional language and the pianistic traditions associated with South African jazz.

Mbaqanga

Mbaqanga emerged in the early 1960s in South Africa's urban townships, particularly Johannesburg. Meaning 'everyday cornmeal porridge', the term signifies the genre's role as essential 'musical sustenance' for the urban poor (Mbaqanga, [s.a.]). It served as a vital form of cultural resistance during Apartheid, popularised by producer Rupert Bopape and the Makgona Tsohle Band (ibid.).

Harmonically, mbaqanga utilises the cyclical structures of marabi, typically following a strict I-IV-V-I progression. Reddy's use of modal harmonic frameworks - such as the Lydian mode in the *Toccata* - may be interpreted as part of a broader engagement with modal approaches that are also present in many South African musical traditions.

Melodically, it features catchy leads played on electric instruments and distinctive vocal arrangements (Dalamba, 2012). Rhythmically, the style incorporates syncopated patterns and polyrhythmic percussion sounds from instruments such as shakers and cowbells (Mbaqanga, [s.a.]).

Kwela

Kwela evolved during the 1950s in South African townships. It was a vibrant street music led by pennywhistle players emulating North American big band jazz (Kubik, 2001). Rooted in the marabi tradition, it expressed urban black identity amidst the hardships of Apartheid. The isiZulu term 'kwela' ironically refers to both an invitation to dance and township slang for 'police vans' (Ulwazi: Kwela!, [s.a.]).

Harmonically, kwela is built on short, cyclically repeating cycles using primary chords (I-IV-V) (Kubik, 2001). Common progressions include I-I-IV-V and I-IV-V-I, providing a stable foundation for improvisation (Allen, 1993:75-76). Melodically, the style features bright, repeated motifs modelled on chord tones, characterised by arpeggiated and scalic passages. Whistlers often used 'bent' notes and blue notes to achieve a jazz-influenced expressive range (Kubik, 2001:79-80). Rhythmically, kwela's

definitive feature is its 'lilting shuffle' or swung beat, typically driven by the rhythm guitar (McNeela, [s.a.]). This upbeat, fast tempo distinguishes it from the driving straight-beat rhythms of marabi and mbaqanga (Kubik, 2001:81).

In Reddy's music, similar motivic processes can be observed in passages where short melodic gestures are repeated and transformed across different harmonic contexts. This technique contributes to the suite's sense of rhythmic vitality and motivic coherence.

Ghoema

Ghoema is a hybrid musical genre rooted in the Creole heritage of Cape Town (Jacobs, 2024). It emerged from a cultural 'melting pot', blending the traditions of enslaved people from East Africa and Indonesia with Khoisan and European influences (Ghoema, Proudly South African, 2020). Historically, it is the heartbeat of the Cape Town Carnival (Kaapse Klopse), representing a vital identity for the Cape Coloured and Malay communities (ibid.).

Harmonically, Ghoema integrates European orchestral elements and gospel, which evolved into the sophisticated structures of Cape jazz and symphonic compositions. Melodically, the style features a mixture of 'Khoisan lament' and 'Malay spice', typically carried by the banjo, trumpet, and saxophone. Rhythmically, the genre is defined by a 'driving primal beat' and a distinctive groove reminiscent of samba. This pulse centres on the ghoema drum, a portable hand drum traditionally crafted from discarded wooden wine barrels. (ibid.)

Elements of similar rhythmic displacement can be identified in the *Mayibuye Suite*, particularly in passages where manual and pedal parts articulate contrasting rhythmic patterns. These interactions create moments where the perception of metre becomes temporarily ambiguous, a feature that resonates with the rhythmic complexity of ghoema-based music.

4. CULTURAL AND HISTORICAL CONTEXT OF *MAYIBUYE SUITE*

The *Mayibuye Suite* was composed in 2001 as the prescribed work for the SAMRO Overseas Scholarship Competition (Van der Merwe, 2016:59). The work was written while Reddy was living in Germany, several years after leaving South Africa. This geographical displacement played an important role in shaping the emotional and conceptual dimensions of the composition.

The title *Mayibuye* derives from a Nguni expression meaning 'come back [to Africa]' (ibid.). The phrase historically carries strong political and cultural connotations within South Africa, having been used during the anti-apartheid struggle as part of the slogan '*Mayibuye iAfrika*' (Africa must return). In the context of Reddy's composition, however, the term primarily expresses a sense of longing for the African continent and the people and places associated with it (ibid.).

In the preface to the score, Reddy describes the suite as an expression of the emotions resulting from his separation from South Africa and from those he loved. At the same time, he emphasises the resilience of the human spirit and its ability to transcend historical and political adversity. Interestingly, Reddy was careful to distance his emotional response from narrow forms of nationalism. Although the suite reflects a deep sense of attachment to Africa, the composer emphasised that he regarded the entire world as the shared home of humanity. This cosmopolitan perspective aligns with his broader artistic philosophy of cultural synthesis.

The suite consists of three movements, each characterised by a distinct stylistic orientation: *Prelude*, *An African Hymn*, and *Toccata*. Reddy himself described these movements as separate pieces rather than traditional movements within a unified classical structure (Van der Merwe, 2016:59). Nonetheless, the work exhibits substantial thematic and structural coherence.

5. ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK

Previous studies of South African organ composition have demonstrated the value of approaches that attend not only to conventional Western analytical categories but also to African musical materials, intercultural processes, and the composers' engagement with South African musical identities. In the case of Reddy's organ works, however, the integration of jazz harmony and rhythm alongside African musical references and classical formal procedures necessitates a more flexible analytical framework.

Recent studies of Reddy's music have therefore adopted an analytical approach that integrates concepts from jazz theory with traditional music analysis (Oosthuizen, 2025:15). Such frameworks enable scholars to identify stylistic elements derived from jazz performance practice and to examine their interaction with classical compositional techniques.

Jazz harmony provides particularly valuable analytical tools in this context. Concepts such as extended chords, modal harmony, chord–scale relationships, and rhythmic groove patterns are essential for understanding the harmonic language of Reddy's music. Scholars such as Terefenko (2014) and Nettles

& Graf (1997) have provided theoretical frameworks that facilitate the analysis of these harmonic structures.

In addition to harmonic analysis, the present investigation also considers rhythmic and textural aspects of the music. African musical traditions frequently employ layered rhythmic structures and polyrhythmic interactions, which play a significant role in the *Mayibuye Suite*. By examining these elements alongside the work's harmonic and formal characteristics, a more comprehensive understanding of the suite's stylistic hybridity can be achieved.

6. JAZZ-THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK AND STYLISTIC VOCABULARY

The integration of jazz idioms into Western organ composition presents significant analytical challenges. Traditional analytical models derived from tonal theory, while useful for examining structural aspects such as voice leading and harmonic progression, often fail to capture the stylistic nuances that emerge when jazz-derived musical language is incorporated into composed works. For this reason, the analysis of Reddy's *Mayibuye Suite* benefits from a hybrid analytical approach that incorporates elements of jazz theory alongside conventional analytical techniques.

Jazz harmony is characterised by several distinctive features that differentiate it from traditional tonal practice. These include the use of extended chord structures (such as ninth, eleventh, and thirteenth chords), modal harmonic frameworks, chromatic inflections derived from the blues scale, and harmonic progressions based on cyclic patterns rather than strict functional tonality (Cooke & Horn, 2002:73). These harmonic resources form a central component of Reddy's compositional language.

A key theoretical perspective relevant to the analysis of Reddy's music is the chord–scale theory, commonly employed in jazz pedagogy. In this approach, harmonic structures are understood in relation to the scales or modes that correspond to them. Rather than interpreting chords primarily as elements within a tonal hierarchy, chord–scale theory treats harmony as a field of modal possibilities that may serve as the basis for improvisation or melodic elaboration. Within this conceptual framework, extended chords function not merely as harmonic embellishments but as indicators of the modal context in which melodic material unfolds.

Another important aspect of jazz harmony is the use of chromatic voice-leading techniques such as chromatic embellishment of dominant chords, tritone substitution, and altered dominants. These harmonic devices introduce colouristic tension and release that differs from the functional cadential

patterns of traditional tonal harmony. In Reddy's music, such harmonic colouration frequently appears within otherwise classical textures, creating a distinctive stylistic synthesis.

Rhythm also plays a crucial role in the jazz idiom. Syncopation, swing-derived rhythmic inflection, and polyrhythmic layering are among the most prominent features of jazz rhythm. In many cases, jazz rhythms derive from African rhythmic traditions, which emphasise cross-rhythms and layered metric structures (Cugny, 2019:170). These rhythmic concepts are particularly relevant in the analysis of the second movement of the *Mayibuye Suite*.

The present analysis therefore considers four primary stylistic parameters:

1. Harmonic language and extended chord structures,
2. Modal frameworks and chord–scale relationships,
3. Rhythmic and metric processes, and
4. Motivic development and thematic transformation.

By investigating these aspects across the three movements of the suite, it becomes possible to identify the ways in which Reddy integrates jazz idioms within the framework of Western organ composition.

7. STYLISTIC SYNTHESIS IN REDDY'S COMPOSITIONAL LANGUAGE

Although the *Mayibuye Suite* does not directly quote specific South African jazz idioms, the work nevertheless reflects the broader stylistic environment in which these traditions developed. Reddy's compositional language integrates several features associated with South African jazz traditions:

- Cyclic harmonic structures reminiscent of marabi,
- Layered rhythmic textures comparable to mbaqanga ensemble writing,
- Motivic repetition similar to kwela melodic construction, and
- Rhythmic displacement analogous to ghoema groove patterns.

Through this synthesis, Reddy creates a musical language that is both cosmopolitan and rooted in the cultural environment of South Africa. The resulting stylistic hybridity reflects the composer's broader artistic philosophy, which sought to bridge the boundaries between classical and jazz traditions while simultaneously engaging with African musical heritage.

Movement I: *Prelude*

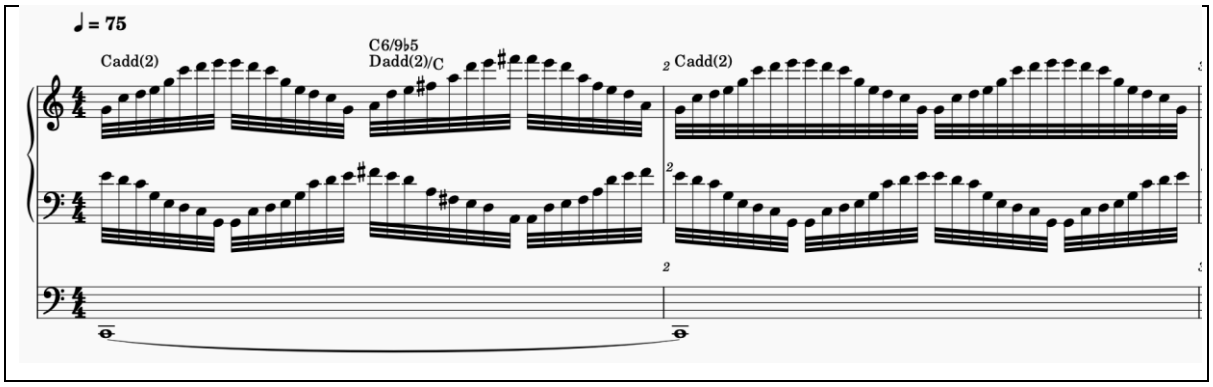
Formal design and textural conception

The opening movement of the *Mayibuye Suite*, titled *Prelude*, establishes many of the central harmonic, rhythmic, and textural principles that permeate the suite. The movement unfolds through an almost uninterrupted stream of arpeggiated figuration, creating a continuous quasi-motoric texture in which harmony, rather than melody, becomes the principal structural determinant. This compositional approach immediately evokes historical precedents within the Western keyboard tradition, particularly the preludes of Johann Sebastian Bach, as well as the virtuoso arpeggiated textures associated with nineteenth-century piano literature.

The movement displays particularly clear stylistic affinities with J.S. Bach's *Prelude in C major*, BWV 846, as well as F. Chopin's *Étude* Op. 10 No. 1. In each of these works, harmonic progression is articulated through a continuous figuration rather than through clearly delineated melodic themes. Reddy's treatment of this texture, however, differs fundamentally from these earlier models in its harmonic language and rhythmic flexibility. Whereas Bach's harmonic syntax remains grounded in functional tonality and Chopin's harmonic vocabulary, despite its chromaticism, remains fundamentally romantic in orientation, Reddy adopts an expanded harmonic idiom derived from jazz harmonic practice.

The opening measures introduce a sequence of rapidly unfolding arpeggiated sonorities that establish the harmonic atmosphere of the movement. Rather than presenting clearly defined cadential progressions, the music moves fluidly between extended harmonic fields. Chords frequently incorporate added seconds, ninths, elevenths, and thirteenths, producing a harmonic palette characterised more by colouristic resonance than by functional progression.

FIGURE 1: *Prelude*, mm. 1-2



At the same time, the texture reflects important stylistic parallels with South African jazz piano traditions, particularly marabi performance practice. Marabi piano playing is frequently characterised by repetitive broken-chord figurations, cyclic harmonic motion, and rhythmic ostinato patterns that sustain continuous momentum (Ballantine, 2001). Reddy adapts these principles to the organ medium, transforming the repetitive accompaniment textures associated with township jazz piano into an expansive concert organ idiom.

The *Prelude* therefore functions simultaneously on several stylistic levels. It evokes the historical keyboard prelude tradition, incorporates jazz-derived harmonic vocabulary, and resonates with accompaniment textures associated with South African urban jazz traditions. This stylistic hybridity immediately establishes the broader aesthetic orientation of the suite.

Harmonic language and harmonic expansion

One of the most striking aspects of the movement is its harmonic syntax. Harmonic progression is not governed primarily by conventional tonic–dominant relationships, but rather by gradual shifts between contrasting harmonic regions connected through chromatic voice-leading and shared intervallic structures. This approach reflects central principles of jazz harmony, where harmonic movement frequently prioritises modal colour and linear voice-leading above traditional functional relationships.

The opening harmonic progression illustrates this clearly. Extended harmonies unfold in succession, gradually intensifying harmonic tension through the accumulation of dissonant extensions and chromatic alterations. Oosthuizen's (2025:189) harmonic reduction of the opening section demonstrates how the progression moves through a sequence of enriched harmonic regions rather than through conventional cadential structures (Fig. 2).

FIGURE 2: Harmonic reduction of the *Prelude*, mm. 1-13

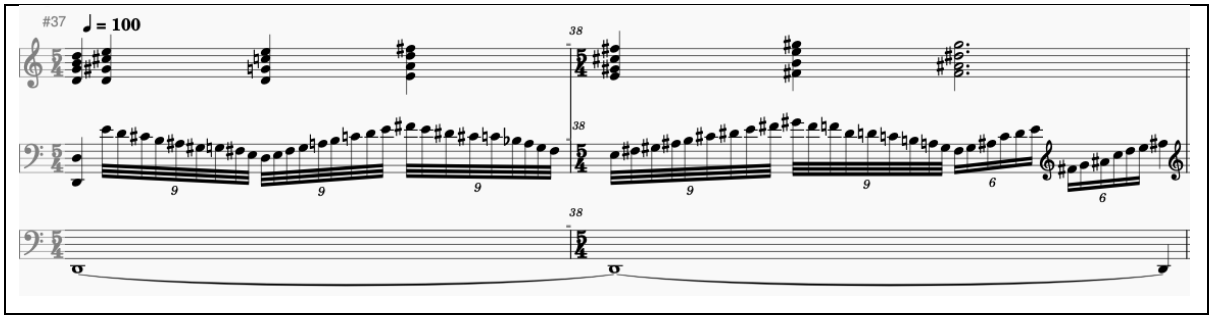
Measures	Enriched chords	Harmonic regions
1-3	C add(2) C6/9 add(♯11) C add(2) C6/9 sus(♯4)	C: I
4	Bmin11 E11 sus2 E♭7♭9	(ii^7 V^7) / vi^7
5	A11 sus2	

	Amin9	
6	AminMaj9/11 Amin9/11	vi^7
7	Amin11b5	
8	Gmaj9/D D13	V^7/V
9	Gmaj9/D D13	
10	G11 sus2	V^7
11		
12		
13		

Particularly significant is Reddy's use of added-note sonorities such as C6/9add(♯11), Bmin11, E11sus2, and AminMaj9/11. These chords derive strongly from jazz harmonic vocabulary and suggest an awareness of chord–scale relationships commonly associated with modal jazz practice. In this context, harmonic colour becomes structurally generative rather than merely decorative. Chord extensions function not simply as embellishments but as defining components of the harmonic language itself.

Another important feature is the frequent use of harmonic oscillation between chord pairs. In passages such as mm. 37–41, rapidly alternating harmonies create a sense of suspended tonal direction and continuous harmonic motion (Fig. 3). These oscillating chord pairs resemble the cyclic harmonic structures associated with marabi and mbaqanga traditions, where repetitive harmonic loops generate rhythmic continuity and cumulative momentum.

FIGURE 3: *Prelude*, mm. 37-38



Tritone relationships also play an important structural role within the movement. Harmonic progression incorporates prominent tritone formations both melodically and vertically, particularly through the recurrence of F♯ within harmonies centred on C. The resulting harmonic ambiguity contributes

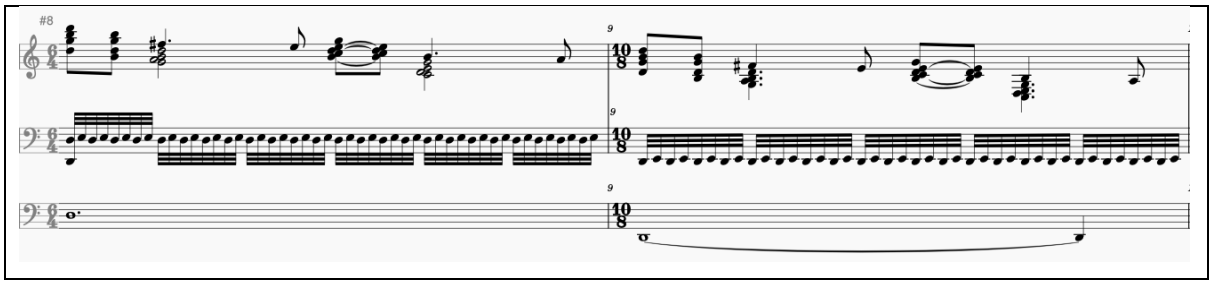
significantly to the movement's modernist tonal atmosphere. Rather than destabilising the music entirely, however, these tritone relationships function as colouristic intensifiers embedded within an otherwise perceptible tonal framework.

Motivic continuity and structural transformation

Although the *Prelude* initially appears highly textural in orientation, motivic continuity nevertheless plays an important structural role. Small intervallic and rhythmic cells recur throughout the movement in transformed guises, often embedded within the arpeggiated figuration itself. These motivic processes contribute to the organic coherence of the movement despite the relative absence of clearly delineated themes.

The *Prelude* also establishes material that later undergoes large-scale transformation in the final movement of the suite. As Reddy (2001) himself observed, the rapidly arpeggiated harmonic sequence introduced in the *Prelude* returns in the *Toccata* in the form of monumental block chords. Although the *Prelude* is dominated by arpeggiated textures, melodic material nevertheless emerges through the upper voices of the harmonic structures. The first clearly identifiable melodic motif appears in mm. 8–9 (Fig. 4). This motif is particularly significant because it later reappears in transformed form within the third movement of the suite. This transformation creates an important cyclical relationship between the opening and closing movements of the suite.

FIGURE 4: *Prelude*, mm. 8-9



Material initially presented as fluid harmonic motion later reappears as rhythmically forceful and structural chordal proclamation. The presence of such thematic relationships demonstrates that the three movements of the suite are linked through subtle motivic connections, despite their contrasting stylistic characters.

This process of transformation reflects broader compositional principles associated with thematic metamorphosis in nineteenth- and twentieth-century music. At the same time, it also resonates with jazz improvisational practice, where harmonic frameworks may be continually reinterpreted through changes in texture, rhythm, and articulation.

Rhythmic flow and performance considerations

Rhythm in the *Prelude* functions primarily as a vehicle for sustained momentum and harmonic continuity. Although the surface rhythm remains relatively constant, subtle rhythmic displacements within the figuration create a flexible sense of pulse that avoids mechanical regularity. The continuous movement of semiquaver patterns contributes to a flowing improvisatory character reminiscent of jazz keyboard improvisation.

From a performance perspective, the movement requires careful control of articulation, voicing, and registration. Since the score contains relatively few interpretative indications, performers could determine how best to shape the harmonic trajectory of the music through subtle gradations of colour and articulation. Excessive *legato* may obscure harmonic clarity, while overly detached articulation risks disrupting the movement's fluid continuity.

The organist could therefore balance clarity with resonance, ensuring that harmonic changes remain perceptible within the dense arpeggiated texture. Registration choices also play an essential role in articulating the movement's large-scale dynamic intensification. Gradual increases in tonal weight and registral expansion contribute significantly to the movement's cumulative expressive trajectory.

Ultimately, the *Prelude* functions not merely as an introductory movement but as the harmonic and conceptual foundation of the entire suite. Through its synthesis of classical keyboard textures, jazz harmonic language, and South African rhythmic sensibilities, the movement establishes the intercultural aesthetic that defines the work as a whole.

Movement II: An African Hymn

Character and cultural significance

In contrast to the virtuosic and continuously unfolding texture of the *Prelude*, the second movement, *An African Hymn*, adopts a contemplative and meditative character. The movement functions as the emotional and spiritual centre of the suite (Reddy 2001:Foreword), providing a moment of introspection between the energetic outer movements. Although the title evokes associations with Christian hymnody, the musical language simultaneously engages with African rhythmic processes, jazz harmonic colouration, and improvisatory expressive practices.

The concept of an 'African hymn' may be interpreted on several symbolic levels. On one level, the title recalls the historical interaction between missionary hymnody and indigenous African musical

traditions. On another level, it suggests a broader process of cultural synthesis in which Western harmonic structures are reimagined through African rhythmic and expressive sensibilities. The movement therefore embodies the intercultural philosophy central to Reddy's broader artistic outlook.

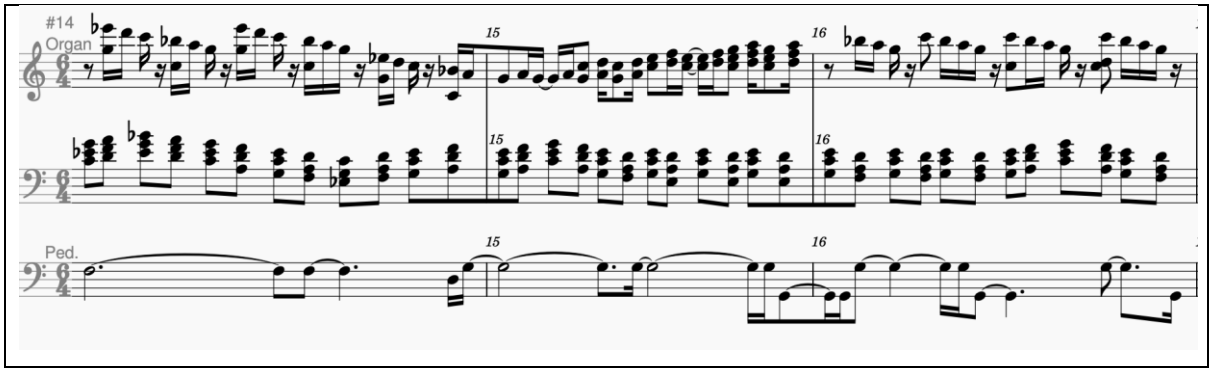
The opening measures establish a restrained and spacious texture in which sustained harmonic sonorities support gradually unfolding melodic gestures. Unlike the perpetual motion of the *Prelude*, musical time in this movement appears expanded and suspended. Harmonic changes occur slowly, allowing the resonance of individual sonorities to assume structural importance. This spaciousness contributes significantly to the movement's atmosphere of contemplation and spiritual introspection.

Polyrhythm and metric ambiguity

One of the defining features of the movement is its rhythmic organisation. African musical traditions frequently employ layered rhythmic structures in which independent patterns interact simultaneously to create composite textures. In *An African Hymn*, this principle is realised through the interaction of three independent musical layers, each functioning with considerable rhythmic autonomy.

The resulting texture frequently obscures the underlying metric structure. Rather than reinforcing a single clearly articulated pulse, the various rhythmic layers interact in ways that destabilise the listener's perception of metre. Particularly striking examples occur in mm. 14–16 (Fig. 5), where rhythmic displacement between manual and pedal parts creates what Terefenko (2014:395) describes as 'pulse masking'. Through this process, rhythmic emphasis becomes fluid and continuously shifting.

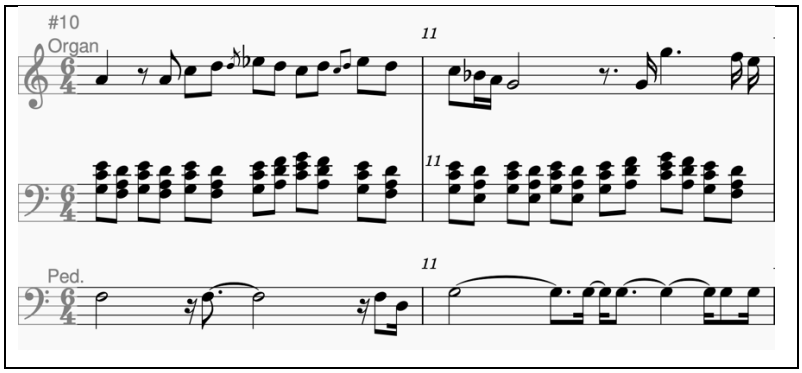
FIGURE 5: *An African Hymn*, mm. 14-16



Further examples of metric ambiguity appear throughout the movement. In mm. 5-7, the melodic linein the right hand forms a polyrhythmic pattern with the other parts and obscures the 6/4 metre with eight dotted quavers in each bar. In passages such as mm. 10–11, subtle shifts in rhythmic grouping create temporary uncertainty regarding the placement of the beat (Fig. 6). These processes resemble rhythmic

principles associated with African ensemble traditions, in which metre often emerges from the interaction of multiple independent rhythmic layers rather than from a single dominant pulse.

FIGURE 6: *An African Hymn*, mm. 10-11



At the same time, these rhythmic interactions also reflect jazz-derived concepts of groove and syncopation. Rather than functioning as isolated rhythmic effects, the syncopated gestures contribute to an ongoing sense of rhythmic elasticity and expressive flexibility. The movement therefore synthesises African polyrhythmic principles with jazz-inflected rhythmic nuance.

Improvisatory melodic style and expressive freedom

Another important characteristic of the movement is its strongly improvisatory melodic style. Although fully notated, the melodic writing frequently suggests the spontaneity and fluidity associated with improvised performances. In the preface to the score, Reddy (2001) explicitly emphasised that the melodic material should be performed with a sense of expressive freedom rather than strict rigidity.

Melodic phrases often unfold in irregular lengths, avoiding symmetrical periodic structures associated with traditional hymnody. Instead, phrases appear to emerge organically from the harmonic texture, expanding and contracting in response to expressive impulses. This flexibility contributes to the movement's highly vocal character.

Harmonic language and modal colouration

The harmonic language of *An African Hymn* combines hymn-like sonorities with jazz-derived harmonic enrichment. Sustained chordal textures frequently incorporate added tones, parallel harmonic motion, and modal inflections that expand the expressive range of the harmonic vocabulary.

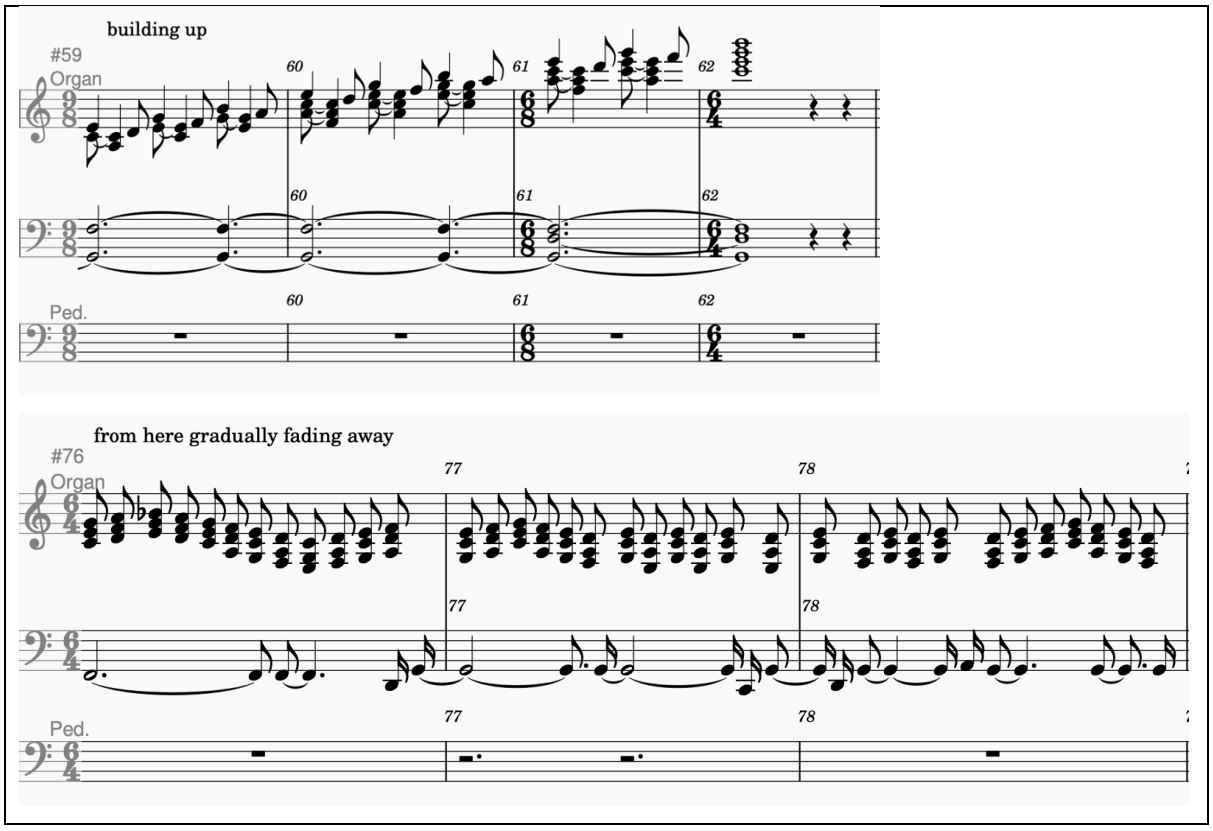
Unlike traditional tonal hymn settings, where harmonic progression generally serves cadential and directional functions, Reddy's harmonic structures often function atmospherically. Chords are valued for their sonorous quality and modal colour rather than purely for their functional relationships. Added ninths, suspended tones, and parallel harmonic structures create a harmonic environment characterised by warmth, resonance, and fluidity.

The resulting sound world occupies an intermediate space between liturgical solemnity and jazz harmonic flexibility. This synthesis reflects Reddy's broader 'clazz' aesthetic, in which classical, jazz, and African idioms coexist within a unified, expressive framework.

Programmatic imagery and symbolic meaning

Toward the conclusion of the movement, the music gradually expands in dynamic intensity and registral breadth before slowly dissolving into silence. Reddy (2001:Preface) suggested that performers should shape this concluding section to evoke the splendour of an African sunset. This programmatic association introduces an important visual and emotional dimension to the movement (Fig. 7).

FIGURE 7: *An Africa Hymn*, mm. 59-62 and 76-78



From a performance perspective, this movement requires exceptional sensitivity to pacing, tonal balance, and colouristic shading. Since the score contains relatively few explicit interpretative

instructions, performers can shape the long melodic and harmonic arcs through subtle variations in registration, articulation, and dynamic nuance. The independent rhythmic layers could then remain sufficiently distinct to preserve the movement's polyrhythmic complexity while simultaneously contributing to an overall sense of expressive unity.

Ultimately, *An African Hymn* functions as the emotional core of the suite. Through its fusion of hymnody, African rhythmic processes, jazz harmonic colouration, and improvisatory expressivity, the movement articulates the deeply human and spiritual dimensions of Reddy's intercultural artistic vision.

Movement III: *Toccata*

Structural overview

The final movement of the suite, *Toccata*, functions as the dramatic culmination of the work's stylistic and structural processes. Whereas the *Prelude* introduced its harmonic material through flowing arpeggiated textures, the *Toccata* reinterprets similar material in the form of monumental block chords. In this way, the movement establishes a cyclical relationship with the opening movement while simultaneously transforming its expressive character.

The movement opens with a powerful ascending sequence of block chords that immediately establishes an atmosphere of rhythmic energy and virtuosic intensity. These opening measures constitute a renewed presentation of the harmonic sequence introduced in the *Prelude*, now transformed from rapid figuration into forceful chordal proclamation. This transformation represents one of the most important structural principles within the suite.

Although the harmonic language remains highly enriched, the opening progression nevertheless retains traces of functional orientation, particularly through the pedal line. The interaction between enriched sonorities and underlying tonal direction contributes significantly to the movement's dramatic tension.

Harmonic language and modal processes

One of the most distinctive harmonic features of the movement is the use of modal frameworks, particularly the C Lydian mode. The recurrent appearance of F♯ within harmonies centred on C introduces the characteristic raised fourth degree associated with the Lydian mode.

In jazz harmonic practice, the Lydian mode is frequently associated with harmonic openness and brightness due to the absence of the tendency toward resolution normally created by the perfect fourth

degree (MacDonald, 2024). Reddy exploits these qualities extensively in the *Toccata*. The raised fourth introduces harmonic expansiveness while simultaneously generating tritone relationships that intensify the harmonic texture.

Tritones occur both vertically and melodically throughout the movement. Oosthuizen (2025:220) notes that tritone formations emerge not only through the F♯–C relationship but also through other intervallic combinations such as A–E♭ in the pedal line. These intervallic tensions contribute to the movement's modern harmonic profile while reinforcing its sense of propulsion and instability.

The harmonic language also reflects broader affinities with South African jazz idioms such as mbaqanga and marabi, both of which rely heavily on cyclic harmonic structures. Although Reddy's harmonic vocabulary is considerably more chromatic and enriched, the repetitive and groove-oriented quality of many passages nevertheless recalls these traditions.

Jazz-derived rhythmic language

Rhythm occupies a central role within the *Toccata*. The movement incorporates numerous rhythmic features associated with jazz and popular dance idioms, including syncopation, rhythmic displacement, ostinato patterns, and layered metric interaction.

Particularly important is the role of groove. The second large section of the movement, beginning around m. 37, establishes a highly energised rhythmic environment in which pedal ostinati, syncopated comping chords, and displaced accents interact continuously. Reddy (in van der Merwe, 2016:59) states that he 'found the idea of incorporating disco influences in a piece for organ – essentially a church instrument – quite irresistible.' Oosthuizen (2025:217) notes that certain rhythmic procedures resemble aspects of disco-derived rhythmic organisation, particularly the projection of an underlying four-beat pulse through syncopated surface activity.

The pedal part plays a particularly significant role in establishing this rhythmic energy. Repeated octave patterns create a pulsating effect reminiscent of kwela pedal points. These repeated tonic and dominant pedal points generate continuous momentum while simultaneously reinforcing the harmonic framework.

At the same time, the left-hand comping chords strongly resemble jazz keyboard accompaniment practices. Short, percussive chordal interjections occur on both strong and weak beats, creating syncopated rhythmic interplay with the pedal line. These textures evoke the performance practices of jazz pianists and electronic keyboard players, adapted here to the resources of the organ.

Rhythmic displacement

The movement's rhythmic complexity also reflects affinities with South African jazz traditions such as ghoema and kwela. Contrasting rhythmic layers frequently create temporary ambiguity regarding metric emphasis, producing a sensation of rhythmic suspension and displacement. These interactions resemble the layered groove structures characteristic of Cape jazz and ghoema traditions (Coplan in Thorpe, 2018:11). The alternation between stable pulse and rhythmic displacement contributes significantly to the movement's energetic character. Syncopated accents and strategically placed rests continuously destabilise the listener's expectations while preserving an underlying sense of forward propulsion.

The *Toccata,* therefore, embodies one of the clearest manifestations of Reddy's 'clazz' aesthetic. Classical toccata virtuosity, jazz harmonic language, African rhythmic layering, and popular dance-derived groove structures coexist within a single integrated musical language.

Virtuosity and performance practice

From a performance perspective, the *Toccata* presents considerable technical and interpretative challenges. The movement demands exceptional rhythmic precision, particularly in passages involving metric displacement and polyrhythmic interaction between manuals and pedals. At the same time, performers should avoid excessive rigidity, as the groove-oriented character of the music requires rhythmic flexibility and vitality.

Registration can also play a crucial expressive role. The monumental block chords of the opening section require powerful tonal resources, while later passages involving rapid rhythmic interaction benefit from greater clarity and articulation.

Culmination of the work

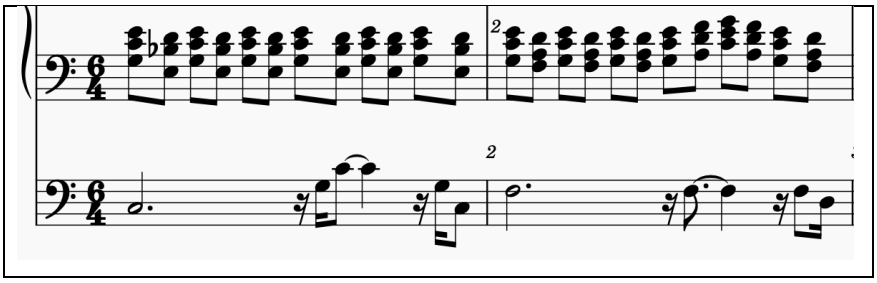
As the concluding movement of the suite, the *Toccata* functions as the culmination of the work's stylistic synthesis. Harmonic material introduced in the *Prelude* returns in transformed form, while rhythmic and modal processes associated with jazz and African musical traditions reach their greatest intensity. The movement may therefore be interpreted symbolically as the point at which the suite's diverse stylistic identities converge most fully. In this sense, the *Toccata* represents not only the dramatic conclusion of the suite, but also the fullest expression of Reddy's broader artistic vision of intercultural musical dialogue.

8. GENERAL INTERPRETIVE CONSIDERATIONS

One of the most distinctive aspects of Reddy's organ music is the relative absence of detailed performance instructions in the score. The composer deliberately avoided providing extensive articulation and registration markings, preferring instead to allow performers considerable interpretative freedom.

Reddy emphasised that the absence of articulation markings should not be interpreted as an indication that all passages should be performed *legato*. Instead, performers are encouraged to determine appropriate articulation through careful analysis of the musical structure and expressive character of each passage. For instance, the triad pairs within the left-hand accompaniment of mm. 1–2 in *An African Hymn* may be interpreted as sigh motives. Conversely, the arch contour created by the triads in m. 2 can be accentuated through a more pronounced *legato* articulation, thereby reinforcing the music's prayerful ethos.

FIGURE 8: An African Hymn (left hand and pedal parts), mm. 1-2



Similarly, the score contains very few registration indications. This absence of prescriptive instructions reflects the practical reality that organs vary greatly in their tonal resources. Performers can therefore adapt their registration choices to the specific instrument on which the work is performed.

Another important consideration is the role of the pedal part. In many passages the pedal line functions not merely as a harmonic foundation but as an independent melodic voice. This requires careful balancing between the pedal and manual parts to ensure clarity within the polyphonic texture.

Although Reddy provides relatively few performance indications in the score of *Mayibuye Suite*, the metronome markings that do occur are significant in establishing the intended rhythmic energy and stylistic character of the music. Tempo is particularly important in jazz-derived idioms, where it functions not merely as a technical parameter but as a determinant of stylistic identity, rhythmic feel, and expressive energy (Cugny, 2019:164, 341). This is especially relevant to *Mayibuye Suite*, in which syncopation, repeated rhythmic patterns, and jazz-derived gestures depend on an appropriate underlying pulse. At the same time, the concept of an underlying pulse is also important in African musical

contexts, where the fundamental beat may be perceived rather than explicitly articulated (Temperley, 2000:68; Agawu, 1995:110).

Reddy's metronome indications in *Mayibuye Suite* should therefore not necessarily be regarded as rigid prescriptions. In the preface to the score, he explicitly states: "I have only indicated the upper limit of tempo, which can happily be taken down a notch or two by the performer if necessary" (Reddy, 2001:2). This qualification is particularly pertinent because some of the indicated tempi appear unusually fast in relation to the technical demands and rhythmic detail of the music. In such instances, the prescribed tempo may be understood less as an absolute performance requirement than as an indication of the upper boundary of the desired rhythmic energy. The performer is consequently afforded a degree of flexibility in determining a tempo that preserves the characteristic rhythmic and stylistic features of the music while remaining appropriate to the instrument, acoustic environment, and practical demands of performance.

The relationship between tempo and stylistic character is particularly evident in passages drawing on jazz- and popular-music idioms. Reddy's tempo markings can, in these instances, be understood as contributing to the establishment of a particular rhythmic *feel*, rather than merely determining speed. The occasional discrepancy between the notated metronome indication and the practical demand of the passage is therefore significant: it suggests that Reddy conceived tempo as a flexible component of performance, subordinate to the preservation of rhythmic character, energy, and stylistic identity.

9. CULTURAL HYBRIDITY AND MUSICAL MEANING

Beyond its purely musical innovations, the *Mayibuye Suite* carries important cultural implications. The work reflects the broader historical and cultural transformations that have shaped South African music in the post-apartheid era.

Reddy's integration of classical, jazz, and African musical elements can be interpreted as a metaphor for cultural dialogue and reconciliation. By combining these stylistic traditions within a single work, the composer challenges the historical separation between Western art music and African musical practices. This synthesis also reflects Reddy's personal artistic philosophy. His music consistently seeks to bridge cultural divides and to create spaces for dialogue between different musical traditions.

At the same time, the *Mayibuye Suite* can be understood as an expression of the composer's own experience of displacement. Living abroad, Reddy experienced a profound sense of connection to Africa

while simultaneously embracing a cosmopolitan artistic outlook. The suite therefore embodies a complex interplay between nostalgia and universality. It expresses both a longing for cultural roots and a belief in the possibility of transcultural artistic expression.

10. CONCLUSION

Surendran Reddy's *Mayibuye Suite* represents a significant contribution to the repertoire of contemporary organ music. Through its integration of classical forms, jazz harmonic language, and African rhythmic concepts, the work exemplifies the stylistic hybridity that characterises much contemporary musical practice. The suite also reflects broader cultural and historical dynamics within South African music. By reimagining the organ as a medium capable of engaging with diverse musical traditions, Reddy expands the expressive possibilities of the instrument and challenges conventional assumptions about its role in contemporary music.

Ultimately, the *Mayibuye Suite* stands as a powerful example of how musical hybridity can serve as a vehicle for cultural dialogue and artistic innovation.

REFERENCES

Agawu, K. (1995). *African rhythm.* Cambridge, UK. Cambridge University Press.

Allen, L.V. (1993). *Pennywhistle kwela: A musical, historical and socio-political analysis*. Unpublished master's thesis. Durban: University of Natal.

Ballantine, C. (2001). 'Marabi', in *Grove Music Online*. doi:https://10.1093/gmo/9781561592630.article.51496.

Cooke, M. & Horn, D. (2002). *The Cambridge Companion to Jazz*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Cugny, L. (2019). J*azz Analysis: A Comprehensive Approach*. Jackson: University Press of Mississippi.

Dalamba, L. (2012). *Gwigwi Mrwebi, ghetto musicians and the jazz imperative: The social and musical dynamics of South African jazz in the 1960s*. WISER Seminar Papers, Wits Institute for Social and Economic Research, 15 October, Johannesburg, South Africa.

Firestone South Africa. (2020). *Ghoema – profoundly South African*. Available: https://firestone.co.za (Accessed 19 May 2026).

Jacobs, S.H. (2024). *The genuine goema captain of Cape Town*. Africa Is a Country. Available: https://africasacountry.com/2024/06/the-genuine-goema-captain-of-cape-town (Accessed 19 May 2026).

Jordaan, G. (2013). "Stefans Grové se Afrika Hymni as evokatiewe klankskildering." *Tydskrif vir Geesteswetenskappe* 53(2): 156–175.

Jordaan, H.G. (2021). *A style discussion of Afrika Hymnus II and Afrika Hymnus III by Stefans Grové*. Unpublished DMus dissertation. Pretoria: University of Pretoria.

Kubik, G. (2001). 'Kwela', in *Grove Music Online*. doi: https://doi.org/10.1093/gmo/9781561592630.article.15727.

Luitingh, W.S. (2010). *Die Suid-Afrikaanse komponis Hendrik ("Henk") Temmingh: 'n biografie en 'n katalogus van sy orrelwerke*. Unpublished MMus dissertation. Pretoria: University of Pretoria.

MacDonald, M. (2024). *The power of modal interchange in jazz: Expanding the harmonic possibilities. Product London*. Available: https://www.productlondon.com/modal-interchange-jazz-harmony/ (Accessed 14 May 2026).

Mbaqanga. [n.d.]. Available: https://africanmusiclibrary.org/genre/Mbaqanga (Accessed 14 May 2026).

McNeela, P. [n.d.]. *Kwela: An introduction to the penny whistle music tradition of South Africa*. The Treble Maker. Available: https://blog.mcneelamusic.com/kwela-an-introduction-to-the-penny-whistle-music-tradition-of-south-africa/ (Accessed 14 May 2026).

Nettles, B. & Graf, R. (1997). *The Chord Scale Theory and Jazz Harmony*. Toronto: Advance Music.

Olowodunoye, F. [n.d.]. *All there is to know about the South African marabi*. AfroGospel Music. Available: https://afrogospelmusic.com/all-there-is-to-know-about-the-south-african-marabi/ (Accessed 14 May 2026).

Oosthuizen, J.E. (2025). *Die gebruik van jazz-stylelemente in die orrelkomposisies van Surendran Reddy* (1962-2010). Unpublished PhD dissertation. Stellenbosch: Stellenbosch University.

Reddy, S. (2001). Composer's notes. In *Mayibuye Suite: For Organ*. London: African Composers Edition.

Surendran Reddy. [n.d.]. Available: http://www.surendran-reddy.com/ (Accessed 14 May 2026).

Temperley, D. (2000). Meter and grouping in African music: A view from music theory. *Ethnomusicology.* 44(1):65-96.

Terefenko, D. (2014). *Jazz theory: From Basic to Advanced Study*. First edition. New York: Routledge.

Thorpe, C.J. (2018). *Deconstructing 'The South African jazz feel': Roots, rhythms and features of South African jazz*. Unpublished master's thesis. Makhanda: Rhodes University.

Ulwazi: Kwela!. [n.d.]. Available: https://www.ulwaziprogramme.org/kwela/ (Accessed 14 May 2026).

Van der Merwe, C. (2016). *Surendran Reddy, master of clazz*. Unpublished master's thesis. Stellenbosch: Stellenbosch University.